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The Positive Impact Field Trips Have on Early Education

Museums, zoos, parks, nature walks, science centers, and libraries; the list could continue indefinitely to record places and experiences that shape a young child's life during their education years. Imagine your favorite field trip during your elementary or early middle school years. Think about what impacted you the most on that trip and visualize the joy on your face as you embraced every moment. My children have enjoyed multiple school excursions to the zoo, the Des Moines Science Center, and the Mahaska County Environmental Center. At the end of each outing, my kids come home with a skip in their step, excited to tell me new facts they learned about the world around them. Critics believe that field trips are too financially expensive and take away valuable learning time. However, if we shift our thinking from what traditional education looks like and view field trips with an open mind, we will understand the importance of these outings. School-related trips are vital for academic success in the classroom and instilling a deeper understanding of the outside world.

A valid concern about field trips is that they take valuable time away from the classroom and are a financial burden. "Financial pressures force schools to make difficult

decisions about how to allocate scarce resources, and field trips are increasingly seen as an unnecessary frill” (Greene et al. The Educational Value of Field Trips). A suggested proposal is that schools allocate funds more for programs that could raise students' performance on standardized tests than for less-quantifiable experiences like field trips (Heubeck). Exams and assessments provide physical results of a student's academic success, which supplies a good argument for students to remain in the classroom.

However, a study by the U.S. Travel Association provides a different outlook: “Children who take school trips have better grades by 59%, higher graduation rates from high school by 95% and college by 93% and greater income by 12% annually” (qtd. in Asasa). Schools who supply their students with adventures outside of the classroom will see a greater return in academic success as children are able to absorb learning in new environments and contexts. “By creating an adventure for children we are not only teaching them a great deal but are also... encouraging them to become better students” (Clark 23). Adventure broadens horizons, builds confidence, and reveals new personal capabilities. Students use this time to discover their resilience and put things into perspective, which is especially useful when they are getting ready for tests (Mendip Activity Centre: The Benefits of Technology-free School Trips). The process of integrating classroom materials into life experiences gives children visual examples of when and where to utilize those materials and the benefit they provide to the student (Akinyanju et al. 2).

“Field trips are used to expand the world of the child and to stimulate his interest in what is around him” (DuVall and Krepel 639). Consider a kindergarten class studying nutrition and they learn the importance of drinking a glass of milk each day. Most children

drink milk, but few know where it comes from and the work it takes to generate it. When you take the children out of the classroom and visit a working dairy barn, you cultivate space for a dairy expert to answer questions and the creation of a lasting visual in young minds. In an interview on October 30, 2024, Meghan Moorman, kindergarten teacher at Oskaloosa Elementary School, expressed that field trips provide hands-on activities that better students' understanding by creating a memory of themselves experiencing a real-life experience.

School orchestrated trips are invaluable to student success. Learners thrive academically and gain a better understanding of the outside world when they experience new environments and contexts of learning. "Today's students are visual learners, and a field trip lets them touch, feel and listen to what they're learning about, which helps them build on classroom instruction, gain a better understanding of topics, build cultural understanding and tolerance, and expose them to worlds outside their own" (Benefits). For a child, a flower will stay an abstract object in his/her reality until hands have touched the petals, a nose has smelled the fragrance, and eyes have seen vibrant colors of the plant. Encourage and impress upon your local schools the importance of these excursions and then watch students flourish as they encounter new ways to experience education and the world around them.

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